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THREAT INTELLIGENCE • MALWARE ANALYSIS • DETECTION ENGINEERING

# WordPress Core CVE-2026-119977 Exploited Upgrade-Window RCE Daily Priority

CVE / Vulnerability Threat Intelligence Report

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TLP:CLEAR | Lost Boys Cyber | WordPress Core CVE-2026-119977 Exploited Upgrade-Window RCE Daily Priority - CVE / Vulnerability Threat Intelligence Report

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AI Generation: This report was generated with AI assistance and is provided for informational purposes only. All findings, IOCs, detection rules, hunting queries, attribution assessments, and recommendations must be independently reviewed and validated by a qualified security professional before operational use.

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# WordPress Core CVE-2026-119977 Exploited Upgrade-Window RCE Daily Priority

## 1. Executive Summary

CVE-2026-119977 is a high-severity WordPress Core remote-code-execution condition affecting versions 4.7 through 7.1.3. CISA added it to the Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog on 2026-11-03 based on evidence of active exploitation. The disclosed condition involves predictable, web-accessible staging paths during a full-package core upgrade; an unauthenticated attacker may use the upgrade window to place and execute server-side code.

This is a web-tier incident-response priority, not solely a routine content-management patch. Organizations should identify exposed WordPress estates, apply the vendor-fixed release, review web-server and application telemetry around upgrade activity, and inspect for unexpected PHP files or administrative changes. This report does not attribute the exploitation activity to a named actor; public CISA material confirms exploitation but does not identify a campaign.

## 2. Vulnerability Metadata

| Field | Value |
|---|---|
| CVE | CVE-2026-119977 |
| Product / Component | WordPress Core full-package upgrade workflow |
| Weakness | CWE-367 / CWE-552 described by public CVE records |
| Severity | High; public trackers list CVSS 8.1 |
| Affected Versions | WordPress Core 4.7 through 7.1.3 |
| Fixed Version | 7.1.4 according to supporting public reporting; validate against WordPress release guidance before change |
| Disclosure / KEV context | NVD entry dated 2026-10-30; CISA KEV alert dated 2026-11-03 |
| Exploitation Status | CISA KEV: actively exploited |

## 3. Source Review & Confidence

| Source | Contribution | Confidence |
|---|---|---|
| CISA KEV alert | Authoritative active-exploitation statement and remediation urgency | High |
| NVD CVE record | Affected range and technical description | High |
| Tenable CVE record | Independent reproduction of the public CVE description | Medium |
| BleepingComputer / Wordfence reporting | Supporting operational context on reported attack volume | Medium |

The vulnerability mechanics and affected range are supported by CISA/NVD and independent CVE coverage. The fixed-version statement and reported blocking volume are supporting context, not a substitute for testing the organization’s actual WordPress deployment and maintenance process.

## 4. Vulnerability Details

The public description states that full-package upgrades use predictable staging paths that are web accessible. That combination creates a narrow but dangerous condition: an unauthenticated party that can interact with the exposed web application during the upgrade window may place a payload into a location that the web tier subsequently executes. The disclosed issue is not evidence that every WordPress request can execute code; the relevant risk is tied to the upgrade workflow and its temporary filesystem exposure.

Treat sites with automated core updates, shared hosting, externally reachable administration paths, or weak separation between deployment and serving directories as higher-priority validation candidates. Backups are important, but they do not establish that a compromised web tier has been cleaned.

## 5. Attack Scenarios

| Scenario | Preconditions | Defender focus |
|---|---|---|
| Opportunistic internet scan | Exposed affected site enters a full-package upgrade | Patch, reduce exposed administration, correlate upgrade and web logs |
| Web-shell follow-on | Code executes during the upgrade window | Hunt for newly written PHP, suspicious child processes, and outbound connections |
| Credential / CMS abuse after foothold | Web-tier compromise leads to content or admin changes | Review WordPress users, plugins, themes, cron, and database changes |

## 6. Threat Landscape & Exploitation Status

CISA’s November 3 KEV addition is the primary reason to prioritize this item. KEV inclusion means the issue has evidence of exploitation in the wild; it does not by itself reveal the actor, victim set, initial-access volume, or a universal exploit path. Supporting reporting cited Wordfence telemetry, but this report does not independently validate that telemetry. Defenders should therefore act on the confirmed exploitation status while keeping campaign-specific conclusions bounded.

## 7. Affected Products and Exposure

| Exposure Pattern | Why It Matters | Priority |
|---|---|---|
| Internet-facing WordPress on affected releases | Attacker can observe and target public upgrade activity | Critical |
| Shared web hosts or pooled PHP workers | A web-tier compromise can affect adjacent operational content or credentials | High |
| Internal-only WordPress with restricted administration | Lower reachability, but patch and validate before next full upgrade | High |
| Patched instance with reviewed logs and file integrity | Residual risk depends on evidence of pre-patch activity | Medium |

## 8. Mitigation and Workarounds

1. Inventory WordPress Core versions and patch affected sites to the vendor-fixed release after normal change control.
2. Prioritize public-facing sites and sites that perform unattended/full-package upgrades.
3. During remediation, preserve relevant web access/error logs, PHP-FPM logs, reverse-proxy logs, and deployment records.
4. Review `wp-content`, web roots, upload directories, themes, plugins, and cron definitions for unexpected executable PHP or recently changed files.

5. Rotate privileged WordPress, hosting-panel, deployment, and database credentials where compromise indicators are found; invalidate active administrative sessions.
6. Keep staging and upgrade directories non-web-accessible where architecture permits, and use file-integrity monitoring on executable web content.

## 9. Detection Engineering

| Signal | Telemetry Source | Analytic Goal |
|---|---|---|
| PHP written under upgrade or upload paths | EDR / FIM / web host audit | Identify executable payload staging |
| Web server spawning shell or downloader tools | EDR process telemetry | Identify post-exploitation from PHP worker context |
| Administrative account or plugin changes near upgrades | WordPress / database / application logs | Identify persistence or account abuse |

### 9.1. Sigma Detection Rule

```
title: Suspicious Shell Spawned by PHP Web Worker
id: 1bc06a0b-03e2-4bb9-a113-04db0c2a1637
status: experimental
logsource:
  product: linux
  category: process_creation
detection:
  parent_php:
    ParentImage|endswith:
      - '/php-fpm'
      - '/apache2'
      - '/httpd'
  shell_or_fetch:
    Image|endswith:
      - '/bin/sh'
      - '/bin/bash'
      - '/usr/bin/curl'
      - '/usr/bin/wget'
  condition: parent_php and shell_or_fetch
level: high
```

### 9.2. Hunt Query

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where InitiatingProcessFileName in~ ('php-fpm', 'apache2', 'httpd')
| where FileName in~ ('sh', 'bash', 'curl', 'wget', 'python', 'perl')
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine, FileName,
ProcessCommandLine
| order by Timestamp desc
```

## 10. Threat Hunting

### 10.1. Hunt Hypothesis

If CVE-2026-119977 was exploited, web-worker processes or recently modified web content may show an anomalous transition from HTTP handling into command execution, downloader use, or newly created server-side code near an upgrade event.

```
DeviceFileEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where FolderPath has_any ('wp-content/upgrade', 'wp-content/uploads', 'wp-content/themes', 'wp-
content/plugins')
| where FileName endswith '.php'
```

```
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, ActionType, FolderPath, FileName, InitiatingProcessFileName,
InitiatingProcessCommandLine
| order by Timestamp desc
```

Triage hits by confirming whether the file is expected from a documented deployment, inspecting its hash/content in a controlled workflow, then correlating to web requests, process starts, and CMS administrator changes.

## 11. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

| Technique | Name | Evidence / Rationale |
|---|---|---|
| T1190 | Exploit Public-Facing Application | Exposed WordPress Core is the relevant entry surface |
| T1505.003 | Web Shell | A plausible post-exploitation persistence pattern; hunt, not confirmed campaign behavior |
| T1059 | Command and Scripting Interpreter | Relevant if web execution transitions to shell commands |

## 12. Validation / Lab Testing

No exploit was executed during this production run. Validation is limited to source review and detection-logic review. Before operational deployment, test patch versioning, log coverage, file-integrity paths, and query field mappings in an authorized staging environment.

## 13. Recommended Actions Summary

| Priority | Owner | Action |
|---|---|---|
| Critical | Web / platform operations | Identify internet-facing affected versions and patch under emergency change control |
| High | Security operations | Preserve logs and hunt for web-worker child processes and unexpected PHP files |
| High | Application owners | Review CMS administrators, plugins, themes, scheduled tasks, and credential exposure |
| Medium | Architecture | Remove web reachability to transient deployment/upgrade content where feasible |

## 14. References


- CISA, “CISA Adds One Known Exploited Vulnerability to Catalog,” 2026-11-03: https://www.cisa.gov/news-events/alerts/2026/11/03/cisa-adds-one-known-exploited-vulnerability-catalog
- NVD, CVE-2026-119977: https://nvd.nist.gov/vuln/detail/CVE-2026-119977
- Tenable, CVE-2026-119977: https://www.tenable.com/cve/CVE-2026-119977
- BleepingComputer, “CISA flags WordPress RCE flaw as actively exploited in attacks”: https://www.bleepingcomputer.com/news/security/cisa-flags-wordpress-rce-flaw-as-actively-exploited-in-attacks/